

Tech-furnishing your office

You want to tech-enable your office, and don't want to waste money on unnecessary expenditure. Here's a primer to get you going on the right track

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The agricultural age was based on ploughs and the animals that pulled them; the industrial age, on engines and the fuels that fed them. The information age we are now creating will be based on computers and the networks that interconnect them.

Folks at Sun Microsystems can now say, "We told you so", and everyone would have to agree. Their famous punch line "The network is the computer" is slowly coming true with the workplace undergoing a major upheaval since the early days of the computer. But merely having a computer and a printer connected on a network are not enough to say that your office is IT-enabled.

With today's technologies, the use of various devices in tandem can help you get the most for your business.

According to researchers at IBM, nearly 70 per cent of all work is collaborative in nature and only 30 per cent is done individually. Why, then, are most offices still made up of individual desks?

Most offices would do well to optimise the way employees work by refurbishing the work-

place to suit today's technological needs. This could, in fact, even help save some money in the bargain. Let's look at the various parts of an office that could be truly 'IT-enabled'.

The Cubicle

Cubicles today are typical—they have a computer, a telephone, sometimes a printer, almost never a scanner and a soft board. Space for the person working in the cubicle is at a premium, and he or she has to manage space and devices efficiently. While a printer is a necessity, a scanner might not be required as frequently.

However, arming every cubicle with a printer could cost the company much more, apart from cramping up the cubicle.

The solution here is simple.

Space could be freed up in a cubicle by strategically placing a multifunctional device (MFD) so that four or more workers in a particular bay could use it. This would also reduce hardware costs in terms of peripherals and maintenance.

Space in the cubicle could be further enhanced by replacing the existing CRT monitor with an LCD one. These certainly take up less space, and although they cost more that would be recovered from the power savings they offer.

Today's executives are tech-savvy and would surely appreciate the extra space made available to them. They have enough devices they would want to either sync with the computer or simply have at hand at work.

Some devices that are now commonplace with today's on-the-go executives include a PDA, a cell phone, digital camera, pen drives and more. The computer in his or her cubicle should have at least two USB slots to accommodate two of the above devices at a time.

There are enough executives who would like to sync their PDA with their computer and cell phone, and add digital images in a presentation saved on the pen drive!

But is this a practical way of working? Sandeep Mehrotra, sales manager, Adobe Systems India, says, "I think offices that incorporate technology in a big way will not only reap benefits in terms of saving costs but also see a great deal of increase in productivity. Technology will be an enabler in making the office an enjoyable and comfortable environment."

V Krishnan, general manager, consumer sales, imaging and printing, HP India, agrees: "A tech-intensive office will definitely involve a